In Memoriam: Kimuli Kasara

RESTING PAPERS

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Kimuli Kasara *was Associate Professor of Political Science at Columbia University.*

Kimuli's webpage is spare. It reflects her horror at having to write anything remotely resembling self-promotion and an instinctual aversion to overexplaining. It contains a section for her political song competition where she had students scout for YouTube videos of politicians wooing electorates with song and dance, extolling heroic leaders, lambasting liberals, getting out the vote. Kimuli countering the awfulness of Covid, and the sterility of textbooks, by getting her "kids" to connect with the madness and energy of real politics.

In a quieter part of the page she links to her major pieces. A precious collection. She leads with what's probably her best-known piece, "Tax me if you can." "Tax me" is a polite piece, if you know Kimuli. She's gently suggesting how interesting it is that if you look carefully you'll notice that politicians extract from co-ethnics. But really it's berating us, incredulous, as Kimuli often was, at the naïve takes we have on ethnic groups. How can we be thinking of these like coalitions or clubs, looking out for each other, when they are so obviously messy networks of dependencies and information flows that can be used as much for internal exploitation as for support?

Later come the brilliant pieces with Pavi Suryanarayan and Isabella Mares and two lovely pieces looking at residential segregation, including one using a clever strategy for figuring out causal effects using Kenya's land settlements history.

At the bottom though, after the working papers (one of which, Kimuli, I will try to finish up soon!), she has a section called "resting papers." Four fully developed papers that aren't in general circulation— two have dead links and two none at all. These are papers that meant a lot to Kimuli and were with her for a long time. Now resting.

I want to talk about these four resting papers, and draw attention especially to the last three.

The first is "Electoral Geography and Conflict." This one should have been published an age ago. Lots of work, including by Kimuli, looks at how geography shapes violence. "Electoral Geography" goes the opposite direction and asks how violence shapes demography; does it produce a kind of gerrymandering? When control of an area is important enough, does politics work through demographic engineering? The paper is classic Kimuli: big question, rounded theorizing, new measures, in this case of the political importance of geographic units and satellite imagery to capture violence, and neat strategies to trace the origins of IDPs and figure out the mar-

ginal effects of expulsions on demographic compositions. Characteristically, a rich discussion of underlying logics.

The other three resting papers are quite distinct though and show sides of Kimuli not so well represented in her published work.

"Explaining Ethnic Mobilization in Rwanda and Burundi in the 1950s" (aka "Colonial legacies and ethnic mobilization...") takes a deep dive into colonial history trying to figure out the importance of clan membership for ethnic conflict. A more nuanced take on identity and affiliations sheds light on why Hutus mobilized in some parts of Rwanda but not others as well as differences between Burundi and Rwanda. Re-enforcing clan and ethnic cleavages predict the deposition of chiefs and reduced Tutsi dominance. Awkward findings, these, for a range of existing explanations, including those focused on overly simplistic accounts of ethnic group formation by colonial powers. Still, reading it, you feel a tension. The social scientist's task of extracting a simple narrative hitting up against Kimuli's insistence on remaining faithful to the complexity she saw in the historical and anthropological data, and the many different types of outcomes in different types of places that test the logic. There is here a type of fidelity to a case and tolerance for complexity we don't see nearly enough of.

Resting paper three is "Ethnic Beachheads and Vote Buying: The Creation of New Administrative Districts in Kenya, 1992–2001" (though the copy I have has 1963–2001). Kimuli tries to make sense of the political logics behind district formation, figuring out how changing boundaries change ethnic identification, and the role of ethnicity in political calculus. District formation was used as a payoff for political allegiance but also as part of a forward-looking calculus: a type of divide and rule logic that leaves traces in the splitting up of opposition areas. I always loved the title of the piece, focusing on the creation of "pro-government ethnic beachheads in opposition majority areas." I think Kimuli chose the term to capture the kind of long game strategizing that politicians were engaged in. This strategizing is a big part of the story. But her account colorfully shows the flash decision making and the contradictions—pronouncements by politicians that divisions were not politically motivated, all the while credit claiming aplenty during political rallies. Again, Kimuli builds up an overarching insight, but she also sees many things going on at once that refuse to make for a simple story. She pulls out strands for us. She leaves other threads in place. Others she demolishes. You see her efficient dispatching of alternative simplifying, self-serving, logics—the simple story that politicians try to impose, that these new districts were meant simply to "bring development closer to the people." (That quote is unattributed but she has an interlocutor in mind, who she is roasting as they try to pass off an innocent explanation for the curious pattern of hasty divisions. Oh yeah, Kimuli says, if you were after efficiency it wouldn't be like this you'd be doing it.)

The last of the resting papers, "Selecting an Imperial President: Opposition Coalitions and the Kenyan Presidency, 1991–2002" (aka "A Prize too Large to Share"), tries to make sense of opposition failure in Kenya. The key insight is that when presidents are strong, politics is more likely to take on a winner-takes-all characteristic and credibility problems for opposition coalition members start looming large. As she puts it: op-

position politicians appear to prefer to remain out of power than to form an alternative winning coalition (unspoken: with sharks). Conversely, at a key moment, prospects of a weakened president made coordination to claim the presidency easier. This paper brings yet another method into play. The empirical heart of the work draws on interviews with political leaders and readings of their MOUs and internal agreements. The piece reads almost like a formal model. A qualitative analytic narrative.

I wanted here for these pieces that were dear to Kimuli to get a bit more exposure. They all show her uncompromising mind at work, in a way that can be less obvious in published pieces. I can imagine how Kimuli might react to me drawing attention to these papers and my trying to guess at her thinking in writing them. She'd give me that evil eye. She'd open her eyes wide and say yes yes, you got a part of it alright. But I'd know and know I missed layers of it.

In losing Kimuli we have lost so much. For so many of us, an intellectual inspiration of course. A complex, layered thinker. But also an energy. Someone to keep us honest. A co-conspirator, an ally, a laugh, a smile.